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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Anti-transgender Dems sue Illinois

Group opposes law requiring political party approval for nonprofit names

By Jack O'connor
Chicago Tribune

SPRINGFIELD — A California-based organization calling itself Democrats for an Informed Approach to Gender hoped to file as a nonprofit in Illinois, but instead they filed suit Tuesday against Secretary of State Alexi Giannoulias over the right to use the word “Democrat” in its name.

The newly filed federal lawsuit

highlights a little-known provision of Illinois law barring organizations from incorporating under names containing the words “democrat,” “democratic” or “republican” without the consent of the corresponding party’s state central committee.

Passed and signed in 1988 by moderate GOP Gov. Jim Thompson, the law was used at the time as retribution against the United Republican Fund, a conservative

fundraising group that opposed several Thompson initiatives. Even then, questions were raised about the law’s infringement on First Amendment rights, although the measure was never seriously challenged in court.

Now, it’s in the crosshairs as the California group — which describes itself as being made up of “Democrats, or now politically homeless former Democrats” who oppose their party’s stance on transgender policy — alleges the statute unlawfully restricts their rights by forcing them to obtain approval from Democratic Party of Illinois leadership before they

can legally form as a nonprofit in the state.

Giannoulias, a Democrat, is named as the sole defendant because his office enforces the law. A spokesperson for Giannoulias said the office hadn’t yet seen the lawsuit and would not comment on it.

Illinois Democratic Party spokesperson Gwen Pepin had no comment on the lawsuit and did not address whether the party supported the law. Pepin added that she doesn’t remember the state party ever rejecting a



A group called Democrats for an Informed Approach to Gender filed suit against Illinois Secretary of State Alexi Giannoulias, above, over the right to use “Democrat” in its name. **BRIAN CASSELLA/TRIBUNE**

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An Illinois state trooper tells Cassie Creswell, executive director and president of Illinois Families for Public Schools, she will have to mail a letter she was hoping to deliver to Gov. JB Pritzker calling on him to opt Illinois out of a new federal school voucher program, outside of the governor’s office in the West Loop on Tuesday. **EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Public school supporters urge Pritzker to opt out of vouchers

Federal program allows donors to get tax credits for donating to scholarship-granting nonprofits

By Kate Armanini
Chicago Tribune

Illinois could soon opt into the first federal school voucher program — an initiative long-championed by private school advocates and religious conservatives — but Gov. JB Pritzker has yet to weigh in.

Under the program, part of the Republican One Big Beautiful Bill Act, donors can get a dollar-for-dollar tax credit of up to \$1,700 for giving to scholarship-granting nonprofits. Those scholarships can go to private school tuition, transportation and other education-related expenses.

Supporters say the program

will expand parental choice, and allow low-income students to receive a better or specialized education outside of their neighborhood school.

But critics argue that the program pulls money away from public schools, and undermines the tradition of American public education. Dozens of public school advocates gathered outside of the governor’s office in the West Loop Tuesday morning, demanding that Pritzker choose not to participate.

“We believe that as a public good, public dollars should fund public schools,” said Huu Nguyen, a board member at Illinois Families for Public Schools.

“School voucher programs that take tax dollars to fund private education are the antithesis of public policy that supports the common good.”

The group intended to deliver a letter to Pritzker signed by 46 advocacy, civil rights and labor organizations, including the Illinois Federation of Teachers and the League of Women Voters of Illinois. But they were stopped at the building’s entrance by a state trooper, who instructed them to mail the letter instead.

A spokesperson for Pritzker wrote in a statement that the governor’s office is still reviewing the tax credit.

“We will evaluate the issue

through a lens focused on affordability for working families and what best supports Illinois students, families, and public schools,” according to the statement.

In a July email, however, Pritzker’s office criticized the program, noting that it could “potentially (reduce) state and federal funding for public schools.”

“It’s millions of kids that suffer in the state of Illinois that suffer due to lack of resources in public schools,” said Antwain Miller, a community organizer with the nonprofit Lugenia Burns

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Minnesota shooting twists US gun debate

Some GOP backers reject blaming victim for carrying firearm

By Bill Barrow
and Nicholas Riccardi
Associated Press

Prominent Republicans and gun rights advocates helped elicit a White House turnabout this week after bristling over the administration’s characterization of Alex Pretti, the second person killed this month by federal officers in Minneapolis, as responsible for his own death because he lawfully possessed a weapon.

The death produced no clear shifts in U.S. gun politics or policies, even as President Donald Trump shuffles the lieutenants in charge of his militarized immigration crackdown. But important voices in Trump’s coalition have called for a thorough investigation of Pretti’s death while also criticizing inconsistencies in some Republicans’ Second Amendment stances.

If the dynamic persists, it could give Republicans problems as Trump heads into a midterm election year with voters already growing skeptical of his overall immigration approach. The concern is acute enough that Trump’s top spokeswoman sought Monday to reassert his brand as a staunch gun rights supporter.

“The president supports the Second Amendment rights of law-abiding American citizens, absolutely,” White House press secretary Karoline Leavitt told reporters.

Leavitt qualified that “when you are bearing arms and confronted by law enforcement, you are raising ... the risk of force being used against you.”

That still marked a retreat from the administration’s previous messages about the shooting of Pretti. It came the same day the president dispatched border czar Tom Homan to Minnesota, seemingly elevating him over

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INSIDE



STACEY WESCOTT/TRIBUNE 2024

‘We have taken a nice step this year’

General Manager Kyle Davidson sees progress from the Blackhawks’ rebuild, despite the ups and downs.
Chicago Sports

NTSB HEARING: Investigator details intense air traffic on night jet collided with helicopter in Washington. **Nation & World**

Ill. population flat despite drop in international immigration

By Robert McCoppin
Chicago Tribune

Illinois’ population stayed fairly flat into 2025, following a national trend of low growth due to a historic decrease in net international immigration, according to new figures released on Tuesday by the Census Bureau.

The state’s population increased by 16,108, or 0.001%, to 12,719,141, from July 2024 to July 2025, keeping it the sixth most populous state.

Nationwide, the population grew by 1.8 million, or 0.5%, the slowest rate since the historically low growth rate of 0.2% during the COVID pandemic in 2021. The slowdown also comes after a bump in growth in 2024,

when the country added 3 million people and grew by 1%, the fastest annual population growth rate since 2006.

“With births and deaths remaining relatively stable compared to the prior year, the sharp decline in net international migration is the main reason for the slower growth rate we see today,” said Christine Hartley, assistant division chief for estimates and projections at the Census Bureau.

Net international migration was 1.3 million, a drop of more than half from 2.7 million the year before, due primarily to the Trump administration’s crackdown on immigration, experts

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People walk along North Michigan Avenue on Sunday in Chicago’s Loop. The state’s population increased slightly from July 2024 to July 2025, keeping it the sixth most populous state. **BRIAN CASSELLA/TRIBUNE**